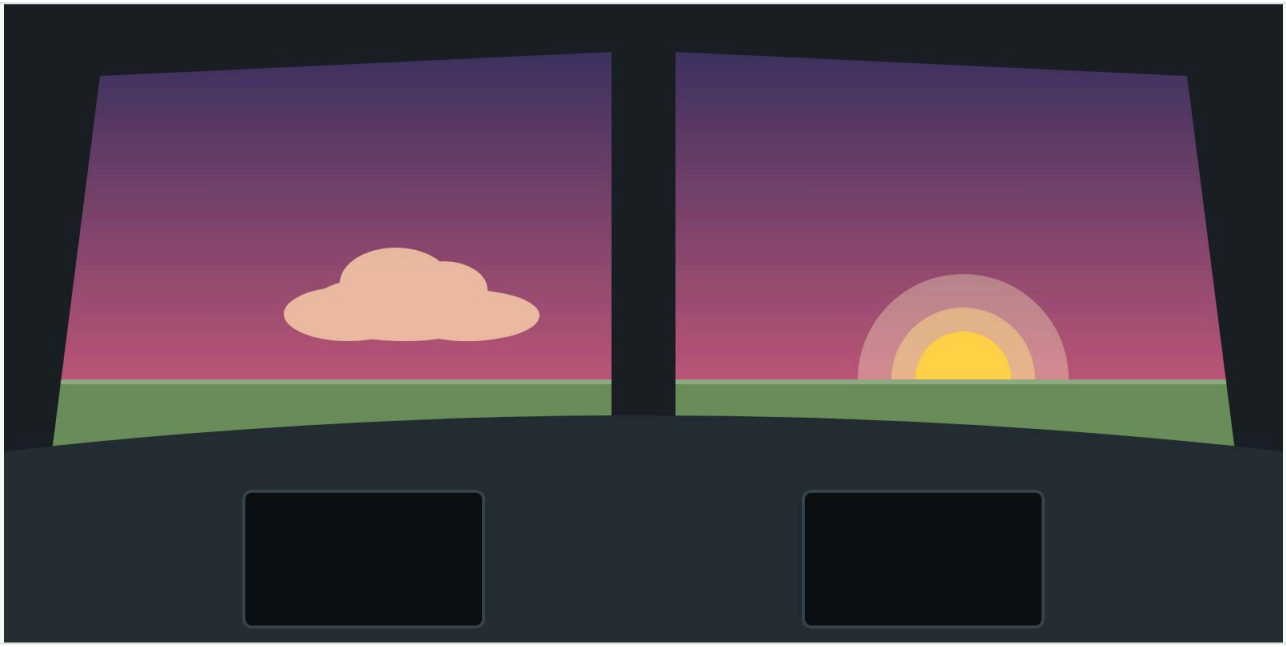
MODULE 1 · RVSM OPERATIONS

Lesson 02: Flight Planning and Pre-flight

Lesson 2 of 6 · about 6 min

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Complete the flight plan correctly for an RVSM flight.
- Perform the RVSM pre-flight checks.
- Apply the MEL to RVSM equipment.



Plan the RVSM flight: flight plan, MEL, weather and equipment.

Flight planning

- In the ICAO flight plan, insert the letter **“W”** in item 10 to indicate RVSM approval (and in a repetitive flight plan, the letter **“Q”** where required by the procedure).
- Verify that the aircraft is RVSM compliant and that no RVSM-related item is open in the technical log.
- Check forecast and reported weather — especially severe turbulence and mountain wave activity at cruise levels.
- Check the **MEL**: the MEL contains the dispatch requirements for systems that need a specific approval, such as RVSM, RNAV and LVO.
- Check any RVSM operating limitations in the AFM.

Pre-flight at the aircraft

- Review the maintenance logs and forms for the serviceability of RVSM equipment.
- During the exterior inspection, check the **static ports** and the condition of the fuselage skin around the pitot-static sources. Damage, dents or residue near the static ports can cause altimetry errors.

- On the ground, compare the altimeters with the known aerodrome elevation. The difference must not exceed the limit in your FCOM (typically about **75 ft**).
- Before take-off, confirm that the RVSM equipment is operative.

GOOD PRACTICE

Brief the RVSM status in the departure briefing: equipment state, MEL items, expected cruise level and any turbulence or mountain wave forecast.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Flight plan item 10: “W” for RVSM approval.
- Check MEL, weather and technical log before an RVSM flight.
- Inspect static ports; compare altimeters with aerodrome elevation (FCOM limit, typically 75 ft).

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Which letter in the ICAO flight plan indicates RVSM approval?

A. R

B. W

C. Y

D. Z

Answer: B. The letter W in item 10 indicates RVSM approval.

Training material only. It does not replace the Aircraft Flight Manual, FCOM, QRH, MEL or the Domestic Airlines Operations Manual, which always take precedence.